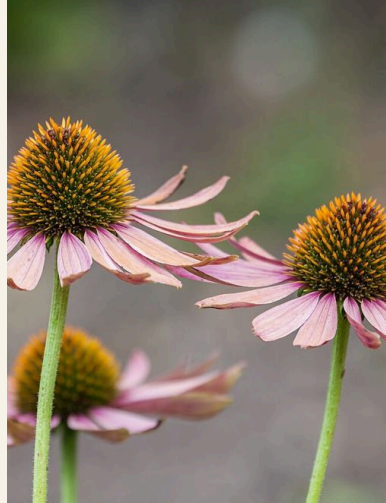




THE HERB PATCH • GROWING GUIDE

# Grow Your Own Medicinal Herb Garden

10 herbs from seed — step by step, from sowing to a jar of dried herbs

# What this guide is

A seed packet gives you seeds. Whether you get a harvest depends on everything the packet leaves out: which seeds need light, which need a month in the fridge, which die if you move them, how much to water, when to pick and how to dry.

This guide covers all of that for ten medicinal herbs, from sowing to a jar of dried herbs — plus **where to buy the seeds**, as single packets or as one kit.

## The ten herbs, easiest first

1. Calendula — Easy, annual
2. Chamomile — Easy, annual
3. California poppy — Easy, annual
4. Chicory — Easy, perennial
5. Yarrow — Easy, perennial
6. Feverfew — Easy, short-lived perennial
7. Echinacea — Medium, perennial
8. Evening primrose — Medium, biennial
9. Marshmallow — Medium, perennial
10. Lavender — Patient, perennial shrub

## How to use it

- Read chapters 1–4 once. They cover the tricks that apply to all ten herbs.
- Use the herb pages as your reference while you grow.
- Print the planner pages at the back and write your dates in.

Traditional uses on this site are history, not medical advice. Before using any herb, talk to a doctor or pharmacist — especially if you are pregnant, nursing, taking medication, or allergic to plants in the daisy family (Asteraceae), which includes seven of the ten herbs here.

# A seed-starting setup on a budget

Six of the ten herbs are best started indoors. You do not need a greenhouse — a shelf, a lamp and some recycled containers are enough.

## Containers

Anything 2–3 inches deep with holes in the bottom: yogurt cups, egg cartons, cut-down milk cartons, or a plastic seed tray. Wash reused containers in hot soapy water — dirty pots spread seedling disease.

## Seed-starting mix

Do not use garden soil; it packs down and carries disease. Buy a bag of seed-starting mix, or make your own:

### Homemade seed mix

1 part coconut coir or peat moss · 1 part perlite or vermiculite · 1 part sifted, well-finished compost. Moisten it until it feels like a wrung-out sponge before you fill the pots.

## Light

A bright south-facing window works for sturdy seedlings in late spring, but in late winter it is too dim and seedlings stretch. A cheap LED shop light is the single best upgrade: hang it 2–4 inches above the seedlings, raise it as they grow, and run it 14–16 hours a day on a plug-in timer.

## Warmth

Most of these seeds germinate best at 60–70°F (16–21°C) — normal room temperature. The top of a fridge or a seedling heat mat speeds up slow starters like lavender.

## Shopping list for the setup

- Seed-starting mix or the homemade recipe above
- Containers or a tray with a clear lid
- LED shop light + timer (optional but worth it)
- Spray bottle, plus labels — chamomile, feverfew and yarrow seedlings look alike for a month
- Zip-lock bags and paper towels (for the cold treatment)

# Three tricks that make or break germination

Most failures come from treating every seed the same way. Three groups need special handling.

## 1. Seeds that need light

**Chamomile, yarrow, feverfew, lavender, evening primrose.** These seeds are tiny and germinate only when light reaches them. If you bury them, they stay asleep.

1. Fill the pot with moist mix and firm it gently.
2. Sprinkle the seeds on top. For dust-fine chamomile, mix the seed with a spoon of dry sand first so you can see where it lands.
3. Press them in with a flat surface — do not cover.
4. Mist the surface and cover the pot with a clear lid or plastic wrap until they sprout, so the surface does not dry out.

## 2. Seeds that need a fake winter

**Echinacea, marshmallow, lavender.** In nature these seeds sit through a cold, damp winter before they sprout. You can copy that in the fridge — gardeners call it cold stratification.

1. Dampen a paper towel (damp, not dripping) or a handful of moist sand.
2. Spread the seeds on it, fold it, put it in a zip-lock bag. Write the herb and the date on the bag.
3. Keep it in the fridge (not the freezer): 2–4 weeks for marshmallow, 3–4 weeks for lavender, about 4 weeks for echinacea.
4. Sow straight from the fridge. Plant any that sprout early right away.

**The lazy option:** sow these three outdoors in late autumn or early winter. Winter does the cold treatment for you and they come up in spring.

## 3. The seed that hates moving

**California poppy** grows a single long taproot and usually dies if transplanted. Always sow it where it will grow — in the garden bed or in its final pot. Chicory has a taproot too; sow it directly as well.

# From seedling to garden

## Watering seedlings

Water from below: stand the pots in a tray of water for 10–20 minutes, then let them drain. The mix should stay moist, never soggy. Overwatering is the main cause of “damping off” — seedlings that suddenly fall over at the soil line.

**Stop damping off:** clean containers, fresh seed mix, water from below, a small fan on low for air movement, and take the lid off as soon as seedlings appear.

## Thinning

When seedlings have their first pair of true leaves (the second pair to appear), keep the strongest one per pot and snip the others at soil level with scissors. Pulling them disturbs the roots of the one you keep.

## Potting up

Move seedlings to a bigger pot (3–4 in) when roots start to show at the drainage holes. Hold them by a leaf, never by the stem.

## Hardening off — do not skip it

Seedlings raised indoors burn and wilt if they go straight outside. Get them used to sun and wind over about a week:

| Day | Where                                                                                  |
|-----|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1–2 | 1–2 hours outside in shade, out of wind                                                |
| 3–4 | 3–4 hours, some morning sun                                                            |
| 5–6 | Most of the day outside, bring in at night                                             |
| 7   | Out day and night if no frost is forecast; plant out on a cloudy day or in the evening |

## Planting out

Dig a hole slightly bigger than the root ball, set the plant at the same depth it was growing, firm the soil and water well. Mulch around (not against) the stems once the soil is warm.

# Your sowing calendar

Everything is timed from your **average last frost date** — the date after which frost is unlikely in spring. In the US, search “last frost date” with your ZIP code; elsewhere, check your national weather service or a local garden centre.

| Herb             | Indoors                                                  | Outdoors                                                   |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|
| Lavender         | Cold-treat 3–4 wks, then sow 10–12 wks before last frost | Plant out 1–2 wks after last frost                         |
| Echinacea        | Cold-treat 4 wks, then sow 8–10 wks before               | Or sow outdoors late autumn                                |
| Marshmallow      | Cold-treat 2–4 wks, then sow 8 wks before                | Or sow outdoors in autumn                                  |
| Yarrow           | 6–8 wks before                                           | Or direct sow after last frost                             |
| Feverfew         | 6–8 wks before                                           | Or direct sow in spring                                    |
| Calendula        | Optional: 6–8 wks before                                 | Direct sow 2–4 wks before last frost; again in late summer |
| Chamomile        | Optional: 6 wks before                                   | Direct sow early spring; repeat every 3–4 wks; or autumn   |
| California poppy | Never                                                    | Direct sow early spring, or autumn in mild climates        |
| Chicory          | —                                                        | Direct sow early spring or late summer                     |
| Evening primrose | —                                                        | Direct sow spring or autumn; flowers the next year         |

**Example:** last frost around May 1 → cold-treat lavender in early January, sow it in mid-February; start echinacea and marshmallow in early March; yarrow and feverfew in mid-March; sow calendula and chamomile outside in April.

# Calendula

*Calendula officinalis* · pot marigold · Daisy family (Asteraceae)



Photo: Ermell, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

The easiest one to start with: big curved seeds, fast flowers, and it blooms until frost.

|              |                                                                                   |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Annual                                                                            |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                                              |
| Sun          | 6–8 hours of sun. In very hot summers, afternoon shade keeps it flowering longer. |
| Soil         | Average, well-drained                                                             |
| Sowing depth | ¼–½ in (6–12 mm) — cover the seeds, they germinate in darkness                    |
| Germination  | 7–14 days at 60–70°F (16–21°C)                                                    |
| When to sow  | Direct sow in early spring, or indoors 6–8 weeks before last frost                |
| Spacing      | 8–12 in (20–30 cm)                                                                |
| Height       | 12–24 in (30–60 cm)                                                               |
| Flowers      | About 45–60 days after sowing                                                     |

## Step by step

1. Sow outdoors once the hardest frosts are over — calendula shrugs off a light frost. Push each seed ¼–½ inch into the soil and cover it.
2. Keep the soil evenly moist until seedlings appear, usually within one to two weeks.
3. Thin seedlings to 8–12 inches apart. Crowded plants get mildew.

4. Calendula loves cool weather and may pause in midsummer heat. Sow a second round in late summer for autumn flowers.

## **Watering**

About an inch of water a week. Water the soil, not the leaves, in the morning; let the top inch dry between waterings. Wet leaves in humid weather invite powdery mildew.

## **In pots**

Grows well in pots: one plant per 8–10 in (20–25 cm) pot, or three in a 12 in (30 cm) pot. Any pot with drainage holes.

## **Feeding**

Compost dug in at planting is enough. Extra nitrogen gives big leaves and fewer flowers.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Powdery mildew (white dust on leaves) — give plants space, water at the base, pick off affected leaves.
- Aphids on buds — knock them off with a strong spray of water.
- Slugs on young seedlings — check at dusk, use a beer trap or pick them off.

## **Harvest and drying**

Pick flower heads when fully open, every two or three days — the more you pick, the more it blooms. Dry them on a screen out of direct sun; the petals feel sticky with resin, that is normal.

## **Storing**

Dried flower heads or petals in a sealed glass jar, away from light. Best used within a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

Let a few heads dry on the plant. The curled, C-shaped seeds are ready when they turn brown and fall off easily.

## **A bit of history**

It was called “pot marigold” because it went into the cooking pot: medieval cooks used the petals in soups and to colour butter and cheese, earning it the nickname “poor man’s saffron.” It is a different plant from the common *Tagetes marigold*.

# Chamomile

*Matricaria chamomilla* · German chamomile · Daisy family  
(Asteraceae)



Photo: Alvesgaspar, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

Seeds as fine as dust, flowers in two months, and one of the oldest tea herbs in the world.

|              |                                                                            |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Annual, self-seeding                                                       |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                                       |
| Sun          | 6 hours of sun or more; part shade is fine in hot climates.                |
| Soil         | Average to poor, well-drained                                              |
| Sowing depth | Surface-sow and press in — the tiny seeds need light to germinate          |
| Germination  | 7–14 days at 60–68°F (16–20°C)                                             |
| When to sow  | Direct sow in early spring or autumn, or indoors 6 weeks before last frost |
| Spacing      | 6–8 in (15–20 cm)                                                          |
| Height       | 12–24 in (30–60 cm)                                                        |
| Flowers      | About 6–10 weeks after sowing                                              |

## Step by step

1. Mix the dust-fine seed with a spoon of dry sand so you can see where it lands. Scatter it on raked soil and press it down with a board — do not cover it.
2. Mist or water gently so the seed does not wash away. Keep the surface damp until sprouts appear.

3. Thin to 6–8 inches apart. Chamomile does fine in poor soil; rich soil gives more leaves and fewer flowers.
4. Most seed packets labelled “chamomile” are German chamomile, an annual. Roman chamomile is a low perennial ground cover — check your packet.

## **Watering**

Keep the seed bed damp until plants are a few inches tall. After that, water when the top inch of soil is dry. Established plants handle short dry spells.

## **In pots**

Good in pots and window boxes: several plants in an 8 in (20 cm) pot. Sow straight into the pot.

## **Feeding**

None. Poor soil gives more flowers.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Plants flop over — sow them closer so they hold each other up.
- It finishes flowering in summer heat — sow a new small batch every 3–4 weeks in spring for a longer harvest.
- Aphids — spray off with water.

## **Harvest and drying**

Pick the flower heads on a dry morning when the white petals lie flat or just start to bend back. Keep picking every few days. Dry them on a screen in the shade for one to two weeks, then store in a glass jar.

## **Storing**

Whole dried flower heads in a sealed jar, dark cupboard. Keeps its scent about a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

Leave some heads on the plant until they turn brown and crumbly; it will also sow itself for next year.

## **A bit of history**

Ancient Egyptians associated chamomile with the sun, and it has been one of Europe's everyday tea herbs for centuries. In Beatrix Potter's 1902 tale, Peter Rabbit's mother puts him to bed with a dose of chamomile tea.

# California poppy

*Eschscholzia californica* · golden poppy · Poppy family  
(Papaveraceae)



Photo: Kaldari, Wikimedia Commons, CC0

Never transplant it — sow it where it will grow, and it will come back on its own.

|              |                                                                                                                    |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Annual; short-lived perennial in mild climates (zones 8–10)                                                        |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                                                                               |
| Sun          | Full sun, 6–8 hours or more. In shade it grows leggy and hardly flowers.                                           |
| Soil         | Poor, sandy, well-drained — rich soil means fewer flowers                                                          |
| Sowing depth | Barely cover, about 1/16 in (1–2 mm)                                                                               |
| Germination  | 10–20 days in cool soil, around 55–65°F (13–18°C)                                                                  |
| When to sow  | Direct sow only — it has a taproot and hates being moved. Sow in autumn where winters are mild, or in early spring |
| Spacing      | 6–8 in (15–20 cm)                                                                                                  |
| Height       | 8–18 in (20–45 cm)                                                                                                 |
| Flowers      | About 2–3 months after sowing                                                                                      |

## Step by step

1. Choose the sunniest, driest spot you have. Scatter seed thinly on bare soil and barely cover it.
2. Sow in early spring as soon as the soil can be worked, or in autumn where winters are mild. Cool soil helps it germinate.
3. Thin to 6–8 inches. Do not fertilise — hungry soil gives the most flowers.

4. The flowers close at night and on cloudy days, so do not panic if the bed looks empty on a grey morning.

## **Watering**

Water seedlings until they are established, then only in long droughts. Too much water causes root rot and fewer flowers.

## **In pots**

Fine in pots at least 8 in (20 cm) deep — but sow directly into the pot, never transplant.

## **Feeding**

None. Fertiliser means leaves, not flowers.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Seedlings collapse — soil too wet; let it dry out between waterings.
- Aphids on buds — spray off with water.
- Slugs on young plants.

## **Harvest and drying**

Cut the whole flowering tops on a dry day and hang them in small bundles to dry in a shady, airy place.

## **Storing**

Dried flowering tops in a sealed jar away from light; use within a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

The long, thin pods split open with a snap when ripe. Collect them just as they turn tan, before they burst.

## **A bit of history**

The official state flower of California since 1903. Native Californian peoples used the plant in traditional practice. Despite the name, it is not the opium poppy — it is a different genus.

# Chicory

*Cichorium intybus* · blue sailors · Daisy family (Asteraceae)



Photo: Alvesgaspar, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY 2.5

Sky-blue flowers that open in the morning and close by afternoon — and a root people once roasted like coffee.

|              |                                                                  |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Perennial, zones 3–9                                             |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                             |
| Sun          | Full sun; tolerates light shade.                                 |
| Soil         | Average to poor, deep and well-drained — it grows a long taproot |
| Sowing depth | ¼ in (6 mm)                                                      |
| Germination  | 5–14 days at 60–70°F (16–21°C)                                   |
| When to sow  | Direct sow in early spring, or in late summer                    |
| Spacing      | 8–12 in (20–30 cm)                                               |
| Height       | 2–4 ft (60–120 cm) when flowering                                |
| Flowers      | Usually in the second year                                       |

## Step by step

1. Loosen the soil deeply — the taproot goes down a long way. Sow seeds ¼ inch deep in rows or small groups.
2. Keep moist until seedlings appear, then thin to 8–12 inches apart.
3. Chicory needs almost no care. Water in long dry spells only.
4. In the first year it makes a rosette of leaves; the tall flowering stems usually come in the second summer.

## **Watering**

Moderate. Water deeply now and then rather than a little every day, so the taproot goes down. Drought-tolerant once established.

## **In pots**

Possible only in a deep pot, 12 in (30 cm) or more, because of the taproot. Better in the ground.

## **Feeding**

None, or a little compost at planting.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Slugs on young leaves.
- Aphids — spray off with water.
- Self-seeding into lawns and paths — cut stems after flowering.

## **Harvest and drying**

Young leaves in spring are edible but bitter. Roots are traditionally dug in autumn of the first year, washed, sliced and dried.

## **Storing**

Dried root pieces in a sealed jar. Roast before storing if you want the coffee-style flavour.

## **Saving your own seed**

Seed forms in the flower heads along the stems in late summer. It self-seeds and can spread — cut spent stems if you want to keep it in place.

## **A bit of history**

Egyptians and Romans ate chicory as a vegetable. In 19th-century France, and later in New Orleans, the roasted root was mixed into coffee to stretch it — a tradition New Orleans still keeps.

# Yarrow

*Achillea millefolium* · soldier's woundwort · Daisy family  
(Asteraceae)



Photo: SAplants, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Feathery leaves, flat white flower heads, and a plant that thrives on neglect.

|              |                                                                |
|--------------|----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Perennial, zones 3–9                                           |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                           |
| Sun          | Full sun.                                                      |
| Soil         | Poor to average, well-drained — rich soil makes it floppy      |
| Sowing depth | Surface-sow and press in — the seeds need light to germinate   |
| Germination  | 10–14 days at 64–75°F (18–24°C)                                |
| When to sow  | Indoors 6–8 weeks before last frost, or direct sow after frost |
| Spacing      | 12–18 in (30–45 cm)                                            |
| Height       | 2–3 ft (60–90 cm)                                              |
| Flowers      | Late in the first summer if started early; fully from year two |

## Step by step

1. Fill a tray with moist seed mix, sprinkle the tiny seeds on top and press them in. Do not cover them.
2. Keep the tray warm and in bright light. Seedlings appear in about two weeks.
3. Plant out after the last frost, 12–18 inches apart, in the poorest sunny spot you have.

4. Yarrow spreads by underground runners. Divide the clump every two or three years to keep it tidy.

## **Watering**

Low. Water seedlings and new transplants; established plants need water only in extreme drought.

## **In pots**

Grows well in a 10–12 in (25–30 cm) pot with good drainage.

## **Feeding**

None. Rich soil makes it tall and floppy.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Flopping stems — lean soil, and cut back by half after the first flowers.
- Powdery mildew in humid shade — more sun and air.
- Spreading into neighbours — divide the clump every 2–3 years.

## **Harvest and drying**

Cut flower stems when the flower heads are fully open. Hang them upside down in bundles in a dry, shady place.

## **Storing**

Dried flower heads and leaves in a sealed jar; use within a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

Let a few heads turn brown on the plant and shake the seed into a paper bag.

## **A bit of history**

The genus is named after Achilles, who in Greek legend used the plant on his soldiers' wounds. Old English names like "soldier's woundwort" and "nosebleed plant" come from the same battlefield folklore.

# Feverfew

*Tanacetum parthenium* · featherfew · Daisy family (Asteraceae)



Photo: Juan Carlos Fonseca Mata, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Clouds of tiny white daisies with a sharp, bitter scent that many garden pests dislike.

|              |                                                                                          |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Short-lived perennial, zones 5–9; self-seeds freely                                      |
| Difficulty   | Easy                                                                                     |
| Sun          | Full sun to part shade — one of the few herbs here that copes with a few hours of shade. |
| Soil         | Average, well-drained                                                                    |
| Sowing depth | Surface-sow and press in — the seeds need light to germinate                             |
| Germination  | 7–14 days at 65–70°F (18–21°C)                                                           |
| When to sow  | Indoors 6–8 weeks before last frost, or direct sow in spring                             |
| Spacing      | 12–15 in (30–38 cm)                                                                      |
| Height       | 1–2 ft (30–60 cm)                                                                        |
| Flowers      | First summer if started early                                                            |

## Step by step

1. Sow on the surface of moist seed mix and press in lightly. Keep warm and bright.
2. Pot on seedlings when they have two sets of true leaves.
3. Plant out after the last frost, 12–15 inches apart. It tolerates partial shade better than most herbs here.
4. Cut the plant back by half after the first flush of flowers for a second round.

## **Watering**

Moderate. Let the top inch dry between waterings; it tolerates short droughts.

## **In pots**

Grows well in an 8–10 in (20–25 cm) pot on a patio or balcony.

## **Feeding**

None, or a little compost in spring.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Aphids — spray off with water.
- Plants fade after 2–3 years — keep a few self-sown seedlings as replacements.
- Seedlings everywhere — deadhead if you do not want them.

## **Harvest and drying**

Leaves can be picked once the plant is established; flowers when they open. Hang stems to dry in small bundles.

## **Storing**

Dried leaves and flowers in a sealed jar; use within a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

It drops plenty of seed on its own — you will find seedlings nearby every spring. Pot them up or weed them out.

## **A bit of history**

The name comes from the Latin febrifugia. Feverfew has been part of European cottage gardens and folk practice for centuries.

# Echinacea

*Echinacea purpurea* · purple coneflower · Daisy family  
(Asteraceae)



Photo: Diego Delso, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

The pink coneflower bees and goldfinches love — it needs a fake winter before it sprouts well.

|              |                                                                                                                          |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Perennial, zones 3–9                                                                                                     |
| Difficulty   | Medium                                                                                                                   |
| Sun          | Full sun for the best flowers; light shade is tolerated.                                                                 |
| Soil         | Average, well-drained; drought tolerant once established                                                                 |
| Sowing depth | ⅛–¼ in (3–6 mm)                                                                                                          |
| Germination  | 10–20 days at 65–70°F (18–21°C), better after a cold treatment                                                           |
| When to sow  | Cold-treat the seed, then sow indoors 8–10 weeks before last frost — or sow outdoors in late autumn and let winter do it |
| Spacing      | 18–24 in (45–60 cm)                                                                                                      |
| Height       | 2–4 ft (60–120 cm)                                                                                                       |
| Flowers      | Usually the second summer                                                                                                |

## Step by step

1. Cold treatment: mix the seed with a little damp sand or put it in a damp paper towel, seal in a bag, and keep it in the fridge for about 4 weeks.
2. Sow ⅛–¼ inch deep in pots of seed mix at room temperature. Seedlings appear in two to three weeks.
3. Plant out after the last frost, 18–24 inches apart, in full sun.

4. Do not expect many flowers the first year — it is building roots. From the second summer it blooms for weeks.

## **Watering**

Water regularly in the first season while roots establish. After that it is drought-tolerant. Soggy soil in winter causes crown rot.

## **In pots**

Possible in a large, deep pot (12–16 in / 30–40 cm), but it does best in the ground.

## **Feeding**

None. Rich soil gives weak, floppy stems.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Aster yellows — strange green, twisted flowers. Pull out and bin the plant; it spreads to others.
- Japanese beetles — hand-pick into soapy water in the morning.
- Rabbits eat young plants — protect with a wire ring the first year.

## **Harvest and drying**

Flowers and leaves are cut in summer. Roots are traditionally taken only from plants at least three years old, dug in autumn.

## **Storing**

Dried flowers and leaves, or root pieces, in a sealed jar away from light.

## **Saving your own seed**

Leave the spiky seed heads standing over winter — goldfinches eat from them. Collect some seed once the cones are dark and dry.

## **A bit of history**

Echinacea species were among the most widely used plants of the Great Plains peoples. From the late 1800s it entered American commercial herbal products and is still one of the best-known herbs in the US.

# Evening primrose

*Oenothera biennis* · sundrop · Evening primrose family  
(Onagraceae)



Photo: Christian Ferrer, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Its yellow flowers open at dusk fast enough to watch — and wilt by the next afternoon.

|              |                                                                 |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Biennial, zones 4–9 — leaves the first year, flowers the second |
| Difficulty   | Medium                                                          |
| Sun          | Full sun.                                                       |
| Soil         | Poor, dry, well-drained                                         |
| Sowing depth | Surface-sow or cover very lightly — light helps germination     |
| Germination  | About 2–3 weeks at 65–70°F (18–21°C)                            |
| When to sow  | Direct sow in spring or autumn                                  |
| Spacing      | 12–18 in (30–45 cm)                                             |
| Height       | 3–5 ft (90–150 cm) in the second year                           |
| Flowers      | Second summer                                                   |

## Step by step

1. Scatter seed on bare, sunny, poor soil and press it in. Do not bury it.
2. Keep the surface damp until seedlings appear, then thin to 12–18 inches apart.
3. Year one: a flat rosette of leaves close to the ground. Leave it alone through winter.

4. Year two: a tall stem with yellow flowers that open in the evening for night moths. Sit outside at sunset in July — you can see them unfold in a minute or two.

## **Watering**

Low. It is drought-tolerant; water only in long dry spells.

## **In pots**

Possible, but it grows 3–5 ft tall in year two. Better in the ground.

## **Feeding**

None.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Flea beetles — small holes in leaves; plants usually outgrow them.
- Powdery mildew late in summer — cosmetic, ignore or cut stems.
- Heavy self-seeding — cut stems before capsules open.

## **Harvest and drying**

Seeds are collected in late summer and autumn when the capsules turn brown. The first-year roots were historically eaten as a vegetable.

## **Storing**

The oily seeds go stale quickly: sealed jar in the fridge, use within a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

It self-seeds heavily. Cut the spent stems before the capsules open if you do not want it everywhere.

## **A bit of history**

Native American peoples used evening primrose roots and leaves as food and in traditional practice. Today its seed is the source of the evening primrose oil sold in stores.

# Marshmallow

*Althaea officinalis* · marsh mallow · Mallow family (Malvaceae)



Photo: Krzysztof Golik, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 4.0

Yes, the original marshmallow sweet was made from this plant's root.

|              |                                                                                                           |
|--------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Perennial, zones 3–9                                                                                      |
| Difficulty   | Medium                                                                                                    |
| Sun          | Full sun to part shade.                                                                                   |
| Soil         | Moist, rich — it grows wild in damp meadows and marsh edges                                               |
| Sowing depth | ¼ in (6 mm)                                                                                               |
| Germination  | 2–4 weeks at 60–70°F (16–21°C), often uneven; a cold treatment helps                                      |
| When to sow  | Cold-treat the seed for 2–4 weeks, then sow indoors 8 weeks before last frost — or sow outdoors in autumn |
| Spacing      | 18–24 in (45–60 cm)                                                                                       |
| Height       | 3–5 ft (90–150 cm)                                                                                        |
| Flowers      | Usually the second summer                                                                                 |

## Step by step

1. Put the seed in a damp paper towel in a sealed bag in the fridge for 2–4 weeks. Its hard coat needs the cold.
2. Sow ¼ inch deep in pots of moist seed mix. Be patient — seedlings can trickle up over several weeks.
3. Plant out after frost, 18–24 inches apart, in the dampest sunny corner you have. Water in dry spells; it hates drying out.
4. It grows tall. Give it the back of the bed.

## **Watering**

High — keep the soil evenly moist all season. A layer of mulch helps.

## **In pots**

Only in a big container (5 gallons / 20 litres or more) with daily watering in summer.

## **Feeding**

It likes richer soil than the others: compost in spring is enough.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Rust — orange spots under the leaves. Remove affected leaves, give more air.
- Japanese beetles and flea beetles — hand-pick; plants usually outgrow the damage.
- Tall stems falling over in wind — stake them.

## **Harvest and drying**

Leaves and pale pink flowers are picked in summer. Roots are traditionally dug in autumn of the second year, washed, sliced and dried.

## **Storing**

Dried root pieces and leaves in a sealed jar away from moisture.

## **Saving your own seed**

The round, flat seed heads look like tiny cheese wheels. Pick them when they turn brown.

## **A bit of history**

The plant's root is full of a slippery gel. French confectioners of the 1800s whipped it with sugar and egg white into *pâte de guimauve* — the original marshmallow. Modern marshmallows use gelatin instead.

# Lavender

*Lavandula angustifolia* · English lavender · Mint family  
(Lamiaceae)



Photo: Andrey Butko, Wikimedia Commons, CC BY-SA 3.0

The slowest one from seed — but one plant can live and flower for ten years or more.

|              |                                                                                      |
|--------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Life cycle   | Perennial shrub, zones 5–9                                                           |
| Difficulty   | Patient                                                                              |
| Sun          | Full sun, 8 hours if you can.                                                        |
| Soil         | Lean, very well-drained, neutral to alkaline; wet roots kill it                      |
| Sowing depth | Surface-sow and press in — light helps germination                                   |
| Germination  | 14–28 days at 65–70°F (18–21°C), sometimes longer and uneven; a cold treatment helps |
| When to sow  | Cold-treat 3–4 weeks, then sow indoors 10–12 weeks before last frost                 |
| Spacing      | 18–24 in (45–60 cm)                                                                  |
| Height       | 1–3 ft (30–90 cm)                                                                    |
| Flowers      | A few spikes the first year; full bloom from year two                                |

## Step by step

1. Cold treatment: seed in a damp paper towel, sealed bag, fridge, 3–4 weeks.
2. Sow on the surface of a gritty seed mix, press in, keep at room temperature in bright light. Expect sprouts over two to four weeks — sometimes more.
3. Water seedlings from below and let the top dry between waterings. Soggy mix is the number one killer.

4. Plant out after frost in the sunniest, best-drained spot you have — a raised bed or a slope is ideal. Once established, water rarely.

## **Watering**

Seedlings: water from below. Established plants: water deeply but rarely, and let the soil dry out completely between waterings. Overwatering kills more lavender than cold does.

## **In pots**

Excellent in a clay pot 12–16 in (30–40 cm) wide with gritty mix (add a third of coarse sand or grit). In cold regions, move the pot against a sheltered wall in winter.

## **Feeding**

None. In acidic soil, a light sprinkle of garden lime once a year helps.

## **Problems and fixes**

- Root rot — heavy or wet soil. Plant high, on a mound or in a raised bed.
- Woody, sprawling plants — trim by a third every year after flowering, never into bare wood.
- Winter losses — wet cold is the killer, not dry cold. Good drainage matters most.

## **Harvest and drying**

Cut stems in the morning when about half the buds on a spike are open. Hang bundles upside down in a dark, airy place. After flowering, trim the plant by about a third — but never cut into bare old wood.

## **Storing**

Dried buds in a sealed jar. The scent lasts about a year.

## **Saving your own seed**

Seeds sit inside the dried flower spikes. Rub the spikes over a paper plate to collect them.

## **A bit of history**

Romans scented their baths and laundry with lavender, and its name is often traced to the Latin lavare, “to wash.” It has been a linen-cupboard herb in Europe ever since.

# Harvest, drying and storage

## When to pick

Harvest on a dry morning, after the dew has gone and before the midday heat. Leaves and flowers picked then hold the most aroma.

| Herb             | Part                  | When                                           |
|------------------|-----------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Calendula        | Flower heads          | Fully open, every 2–3 days                     |
| Chamomile        | Flower heads          | Petals flat or bending back                    |
| California poppy | Flowering tops        | In full flower                                 |
| Chicory          | Root; young leaves    | Root in autumn of year 1; leaves in spring     |
| Yarrow           | Flower heads, leaves  | Flowers fully open                             |
| Feverfew         | Leaves, flowers       | Leaves any time; flowers when open             |
| Echinacea        | Flowers, leaves; root | Summer; roots from 3-year-old plants in autumn |
| Evening primrose | Seeds                 | Capsules brown, late summer–autumn             |
| Marshmallow      | Leaves, flowers; root | Summer; root in autumn of year 2               |
| Lavender         | Flower spikes         | About half the buds open                       |

## Three ways to dry

- **Bundles:** 5–10 stems tied with a rubber band (it tightens as stems shrink), hung upside down in a dark, airy room. Slip a paper bag with holes over flowers that drop seed or petals. 1–3 weeks.
- **Screens:** flower heads (chamomile, calendula) in one layer on a window screen or a baking rack lined with paper, in the shade. Turn every few days. 1–2 weeks.
- **Dehydrator:** 95–115°F (35–46°C) for leaves and flowers; up to 125°F (52°C) for chopped roots. Hours instead of weeks. Avoid the oven — even the lowest setting drives off most of the aroma.

## Roots

Scrub them, then chop into small pieces while still fresh — dried roots are as hard as wood.

**Is it dry?**

Leaves and petals crumble; stems snap; root pieces break cleanly. If in doubt, dry longer — damp herbs go mouldy in the jar.

**Storage**

Glass jars with tight lids, labelled with the herb and date, in a dark cupboard. Check the jars after a week: any mist on the glass means the herbs need more drying. Most dried herbs are best within a year.

# The herb garden feeding plan

Here is the rule most gardeners get wrong: **most of these herbs should not be fed.** They come from dry hillsides and poor meadows. Rich soil and fertiliser give them soft, leafy growth, fewer flowers and floppy stems, and many growers find lean-grown herbs more aromatic.

| Never feed                                                                          | Light feeding                           | Likes feeding                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------|
| Lavender, yarrow, California poppy, evening primrose, echinacea, chicory, chamomile | Calendula, feverfew — compost in spring | Marshmallow — compost in spring, liquid feed in poor soil |

## Seedlings: the only time everyone gets fed

Seed mix has few nutrients. Once seedlings have two true leaves, feed every 1–2 weeks with any balanced liquid fertiliser or fish emulsion at **half** the label strength, until they go outside.

## Three homemade liquid feeds

### 1. Nettle tea (nitrogen)

1. Wearing gloves, fill a bucket loosely with young nettle leaves and stems.
2. Cover with water, put a lid on, and leave for 1–2 weeks, stirring every few days. It will smell strongly — keep it away from the house.
3. Strain. Dilute 1 part tea to 10 parts water and pour it on the soil around marshmallow or calendula. For seedlings, 1 to 20.

### 2. Comfrey tea (potassium, for flowers)

Same method with comfrey leaves, 3–5 weeks. Dilute 1 to 15 and use on flowering calendula and marshmallow.

### 3. Compost steep

A shovel of well-finished compost in a bucket of water for 1–3 days, stirred now and then. Dilute to the colour of weak tea. Pour it on the soil, not on leaves you plan to harvest.

## Willow water: root lavender cuttings for free

Lavender from seed is slow. From one plant you can root dozens of cuttings:

1. Soak a handful of chopped young willow twigs in a jar of water for 1–2 days. The water carries natural substances that help cuttings root; gardeners have used it for generations. (Or use a store-bought rooting powder.)

2. In late spring or early summer, cut 3–4 in (8–10 cm) non-flowering shoot tips. Strip the leaves from the bottom half.
3. Stand the cuttings in willow water for a few hours, then push them into pots of half seed mix, half sand.
4. Keep them bright but out of direct sun, under a clear bag, lightly moist. Roots form in 3–6 weeks — a gentle tug meets resistance.

Wood ash: lavender likes neutral to alkaline soil. In acidic soil, a light dusting of wood ash (from untreated wood) around lavender once a year does the same job as garden lime. Never use it near acid-loving plants.

# Where to buy the seeds

## Option 1: all ten in one box

The **Medicinal Garden Kit** has the same ten herbs in one order — 4,818 seeds in 10 packets plus two e-books, according to the seller, with a 365-day money-back guarantee. [See the kit](#) (affiliate link: I earn a commission if you buy, at no extra cost to you).

## Option 2: single packets

**Strictly Medicinal Seeds** ([strictlymedicinalseeds.com](http://strictlymedicinalseeds.com)) sells all ten herbs, certified organic and the correct species — including the true *Oenothera biennis* evening primrose, which many shops replace with a showier cousin. All ten come to about \$50; US shipping is free over \$30. Buy only what you want.

| Herb             | Packet      | Seeds        |
|------------------|-------------|--------------|
| Calendula        | \$5.14      | 50 seeds     |
| Chamomile        | \$5.14      | 500 seeds    |
| California poppy | \$6.44      | 100 seeds    |
| Chicory          | \$3.84      | 100 seeds    |
| Yarrow           | \$5.14      | 200 seeds    |
| Feverfew         | \$5.14      | 100 seeds    |
| Echinacea        | \$5.14      | 100 seeds    |
| Evening primrose | \$3.84      | 100 seeds    |
| Marshmallow      | about \$4–5 | 100 seeds    |
| Lavender         | \$5.14      | 50–100 seeds |

### Buying tips

- Check the Latin name on the packet, not just the common name.
- Seed keeps: stored cool, dry and dark in a sealed jar, most of these stay good for at least 2–3 years. Write the year on the jar.
- Outside the US, a local seed shop is often cheaper than international shipping — the Latin names in this guide travel.

Prices checked September 2026; they change — check before you order.

## PLANNER

# Sowing log

My last frost date: \_\_\_\_\_ My first autumn frost: \_\_\_\_\_

## PLANNER

# Garden map

One square = \_\_\_\_\_. Mark sun and shade, then place each herb.

# Safety

Traditional uses on this site are history, not medical advice. Before using any herb, talk to a doctor or pharmacist — especially if you are pregnant, nursing, taking medication, or allergic to plants in the daisy family (Asteraceae), which includes seven of the ten herbs here.

If you have cats or dogs: the ASPCA lists chamomile, lavender, feverfew and yarrow as toxic to pets. Plant them where pets do not graze, and check the ASPCA plant list for the others.

Never use a plant unless you are certain what it is. Seeds you buy are labelled; plants you find are not.

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